HER OWN REVOLUTION

Falguni Nayar, *60*
Founder & CEO, Nykaa

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Has made her omni channel retail company the go-to online marketplace for beauty products



MANDAR DEODHAR

IT WAS A POEM—GREEK POET C.P. CAFAVY'S 'ITHAKA'—that her daughter Adwaita introduced her to that opened a window for Falguni somewhere. The lines—*Keep Ithaka always in your mind/ Arriving there is what you're destined for//But don't hurry the journey at all//*—made her realise that the journey is more important than the destination.

And so began her journey with Nykaa, an omni channel beauty retail company she founded in 2012, shortly before completing a half century in life. When she decided to launch an IPO (initial public offering) in 2021, it was oversubscribed 82 times and raised Rs 53.5 billion. "It was a landmark moment for a women-founded, new-age, digitally native company to go public," says Falguni. "I was overwhelmed."

Today, Nykaa features among *Time*'s 100 Most Influential Companies, Falguni appeared in *Forbes India*'s World's 100 Most Powerful Women for the fourth year in a row in 2022 and also has a spot on The Bloomberg 50. Awards and accolades have flowed in too: the Isidoro Alvarez Lifetime Achievement Medal in 2023, EY Entrepreneur of the Year in 2022.

For Falguni, it's a personal validation. Turning her back on a successful 20-year career as an investment banker with Kotak Mahindra to take the plunge into entrepreneurship was a leap of faith. "But I had always wanted to create an enterprise that had a life of its own," she says.

The first few years were a roller-coaster ride—from negotiating brand deals to packing and shipping orders themselves to conducting consumer research. There were hurdles aplenty. "App crashes were frequent; our systems would shut every time we saw an uptick in orders." There were trust issues too—people did not trust online retailers. So, Nykaa added authenticity seals to its catalogues and worked only with authorised resellers. Today, Nykaa has come of age. There's Nykaa Fashion, Nykaa Man and SuperStore, a B2B enterprise.

Her family has been an integral part of Falguni's journey. Husband Sanjay, whom she met in business school, is an investment banker too. Their twins—Adwaita and Anchit—now help mum in the business. ■

–Chumki Bharadwaj

SELF-DISCOVERY

"Don't aim for perfection before leaping into something. Fail fast, learn from your mistakes. Failure is not an 'if' but a 'when' question"

REAFFIRMATION EQ *is* better than IQ